I said, “Well, Yasu, my name’s Ron, and here we all go by our first names.”

I liked the idea so much that after the Ottawa meeting, when I met the heads of other nations during their state visits to Washington, I would suggest (unless there was a custom or cultural reason that made it inappropriate) that we go on a first-name basis. It worked wonders in breaking the diplomatic ice. Suddenly, instead of a formal meeting between government officials, you had two *people* sitting across from each other.

Not everything at the Williamsburg summit went as cordially as on that first night when I was asked to explain the “American miracle.”

As I’ve mentioned, in November of 1981 I had made my zero-zero proposal to eliminate all intermediate-range nuclear weapons from Europe. After that, we reopened negotiations with the Russians in Geneva with the proposal on the table. But now, more than a year later, the talks were deadlocked. The Soviets refused to give up their intermediate-range missiles targeted at European cities and accept parity with NATO. I still believed the only acceptable INF agreement was one eliminating *all* intermediate nuclear missiles from Europe. If they wouldn’t give up their missiles, I thought the only way we would persuade them to do it was to proceed with our plans to deploy Pershing II and cruise missiles as a counter to their missiles in Europe.

At the time we met at Williamsburg, the newly developed missiles were almost ready for deployment in Europe. I opened our discussion by reminding the others that the Geneva talks were at an impasse. I thought we had to go ahead and deploy NATO’s new weapons on schedule in order to apply pressure on the Soviets to accept zero-zero parity. After a lengthy discussion, we agreed on the principles of a communiqué incorporating this position, and asked our foreign ministers to draw up a statement